

06

Timing e5, f4, and f5

The central wedge and the f-pawn lever: choosing the break that creates the correct kind of position.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will know when each pawn advance gains space, when it opens lines, and when it simply creates weaknesses.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 031 | PAGE 4

Decode: When e5 gains useful time*e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.*

LESSON 032 | PAGE 8

Play: When e5 gains useful time*e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.*

LESSON 033 | PAGE 12

Decode: f4 supports the space advantage*Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.*

LESSON 034 | PAGE 16

Play: f4 supports the space advantage*Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.*

LESSON 035 | PAGE 20

Decode: f5 as a contact move*f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.*

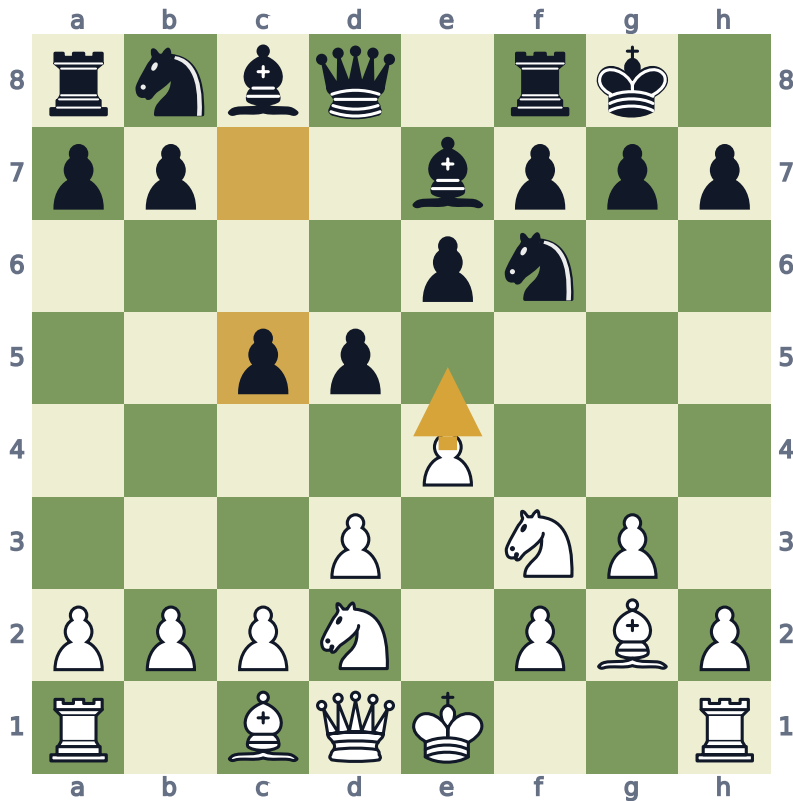
LESSON 036 | PAGE 24

Play: f5 as a contact move*f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will know when each pawn advance gains space, when it opens lines, and when it simply creates weaknesses.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: When e5 gains useful time



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

DECISION RULE

Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses the best knight retreat, prepares ...f6, and uses the time White spent supporting e5 to expand elsewhere.

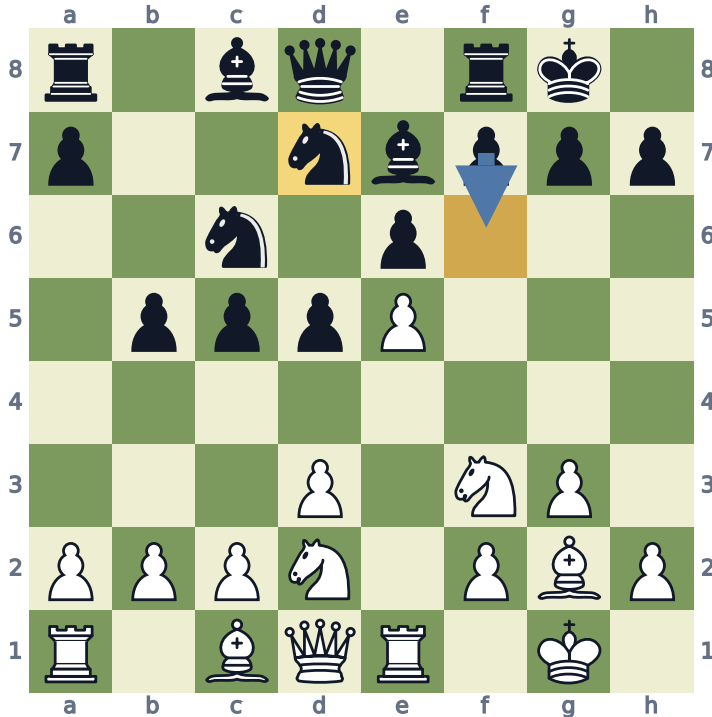
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined.

MEMORY RULE | e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black chooses the best knight retreat, prepares ...f6, and uses the time White spent supporting e5 to expand elsewhere.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined.

FAILURE MODE

Playing e5 when the knight retreat improves Black's position or when the pawn can be undermined immediately.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

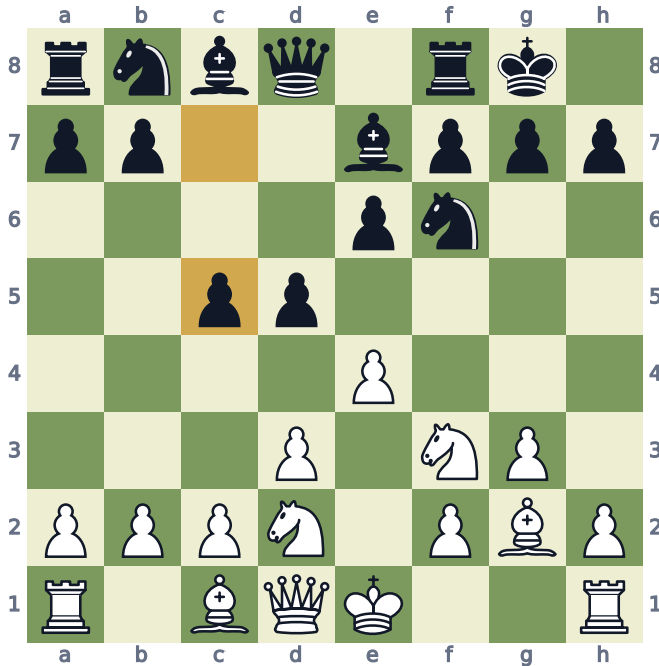
RULE | e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7



- Ngf3: White reroutes a knight to f3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- g3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Bg2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined. The line fails as a template when: Playing e5 when the knight retreat improves Black's position or when the pawn can be undermined immediately.

STORE THIS | e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

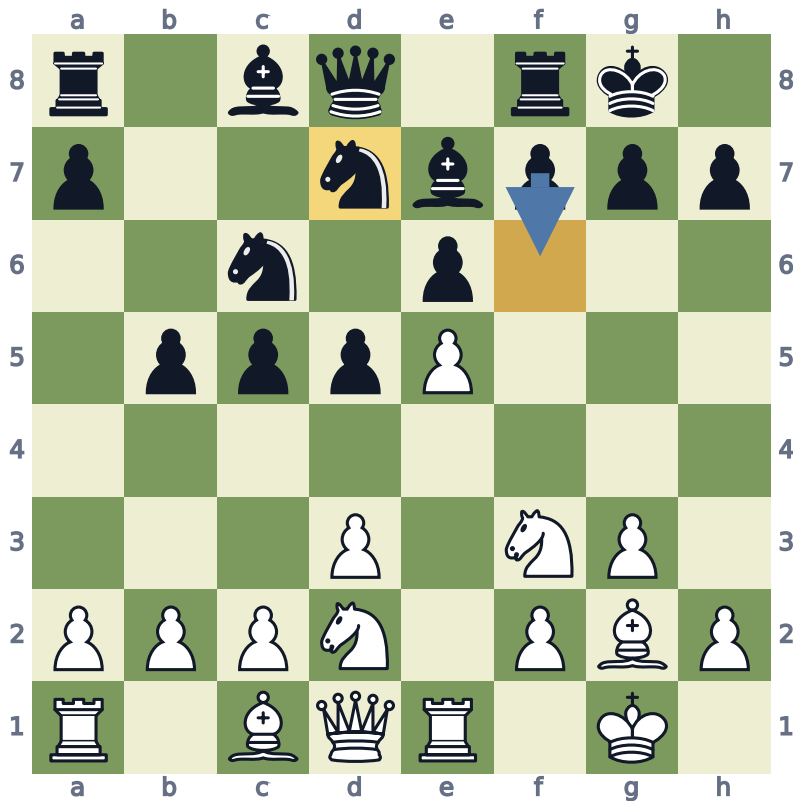
1. e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6. 2. Black chooses the best knight retreat, prepares ...f6, and uses the time White spent supporting e5 to expand elsewhere. 3. White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined. 4. Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king? 5. Playing e5 when the knight retreat improves Black's position or when the pawn can be undermined immediately.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: When e5 gains useful time



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

DECISION RULE

Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses the best knight retreat, prepares ...f6, and uses the time White spent supporting e5 to expand elsewhere.

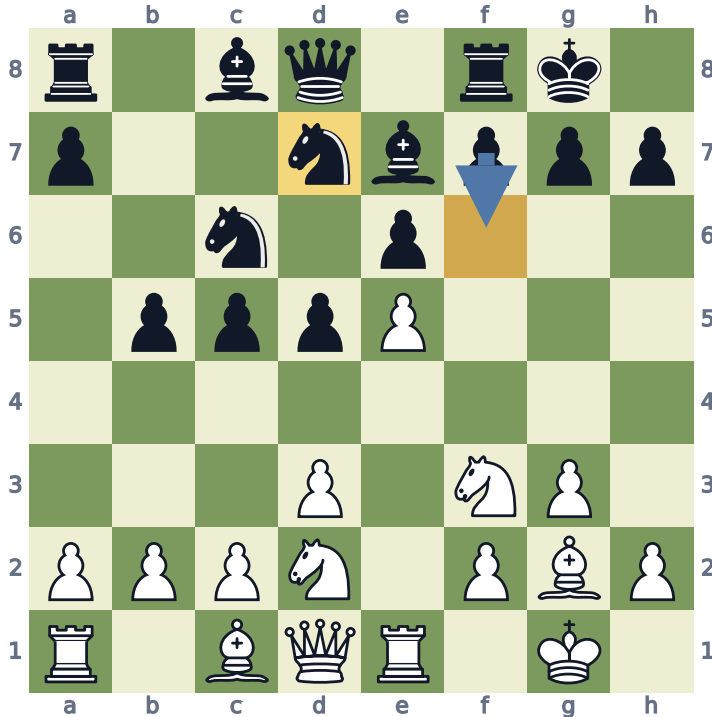
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined.

MEMORY RULE | e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black chooses the best knight retreat, prepares ...f6, and uses the time White spent supporting e5 to expand elsewhere.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined.

FAILURE MODE

Playing e5 when the knight retreat improves Black's position or when the pawn can be undermined immediately.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

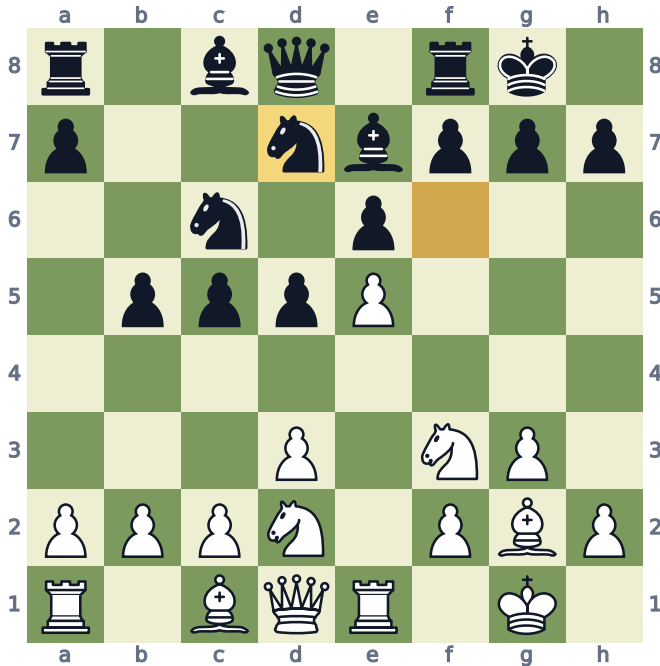
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

e5 is strongest when the f6 knight must move to a less useful square and Black cannot immediately destroy the pawn chain with ...f6.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the knight tempo to play h4, Nf1, or Bf4 and establishes the attacking routes before the center is undermined. The line fails as a template when: Playing e5 when the knight retreat improves Black's position or when the pawn can be undermined immediately.

STORE THIS | e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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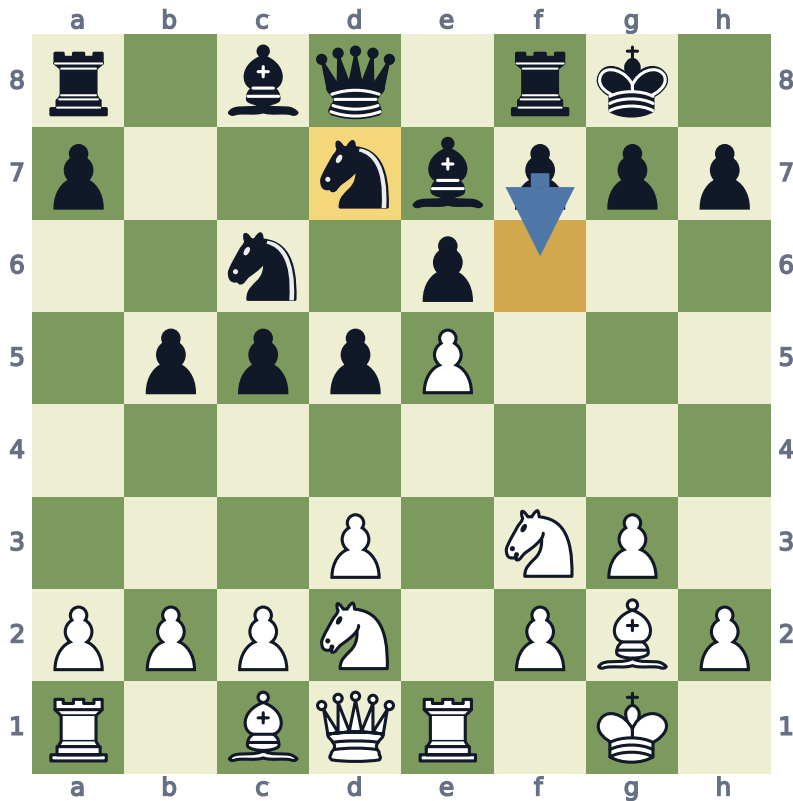
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: f4 supports the space advantage



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

DECISION RULE

Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king.

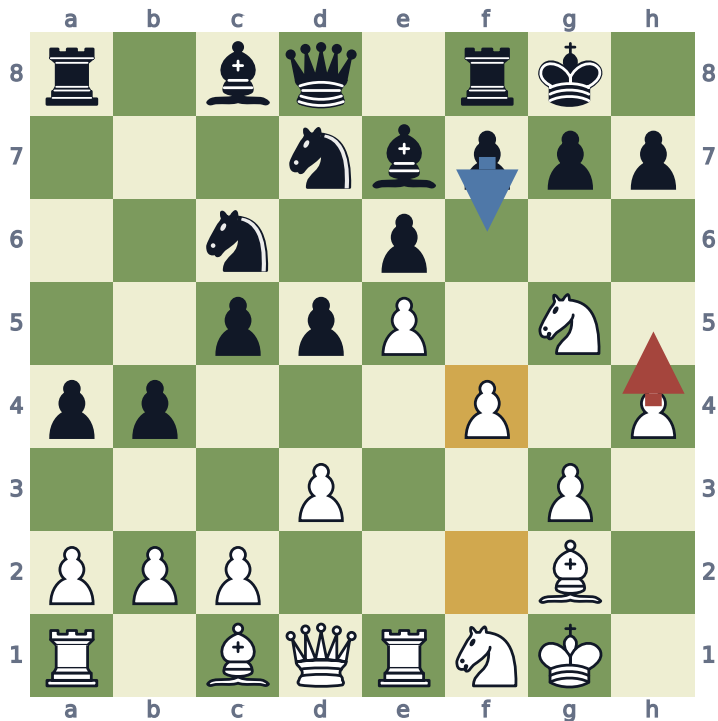
WHITE'S PLAN

White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece.

MEMORY RULE | Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece.

FAILURE MODE

Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

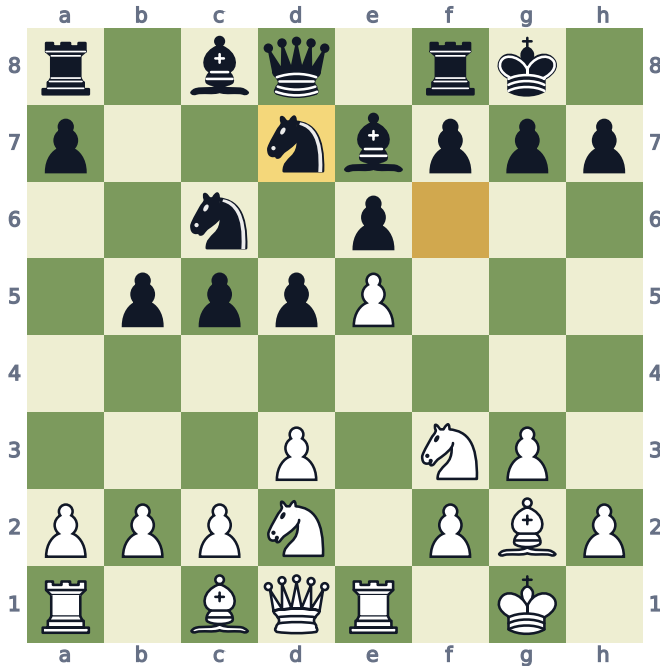
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? White's attacking or positional plan is: White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece. The line fails as a template when: Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

STORE THIS | Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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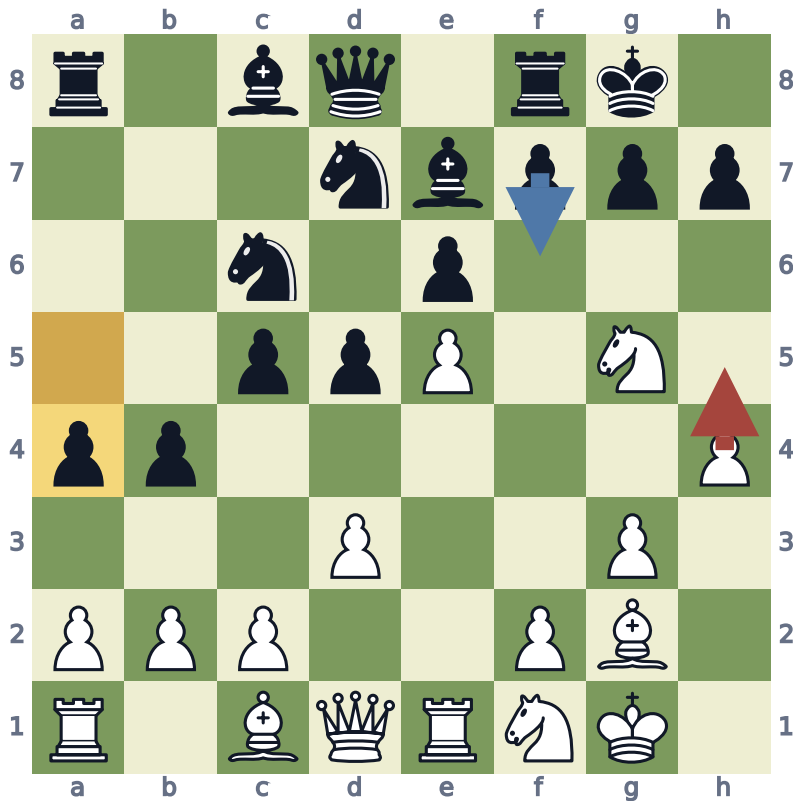
1. f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack. 2. Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king. 3. White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece. 4. Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? 5. Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: f4 supports the space advantage



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

DECISION RULE

Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king.

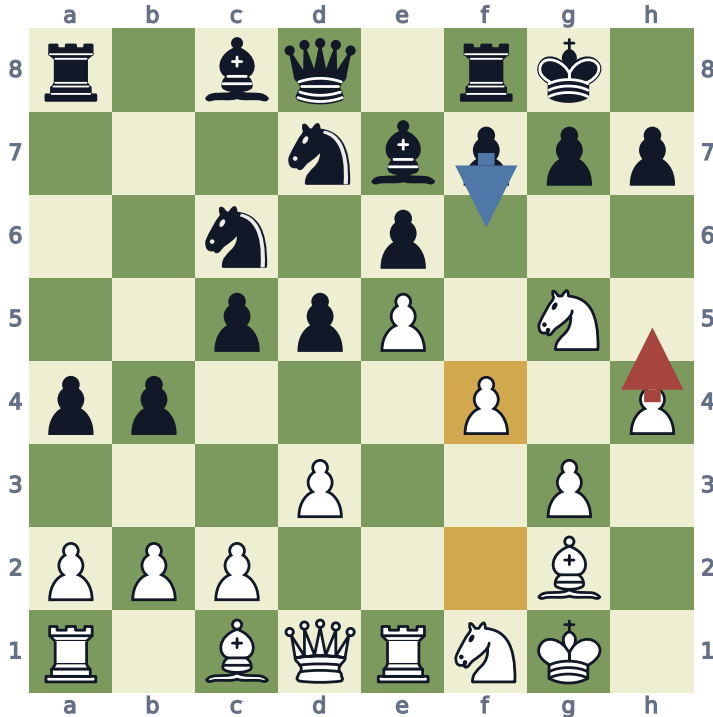
WHITE'S PLAN

White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece.

MEMORY RULE | Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece.

FAILURE MODE

Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

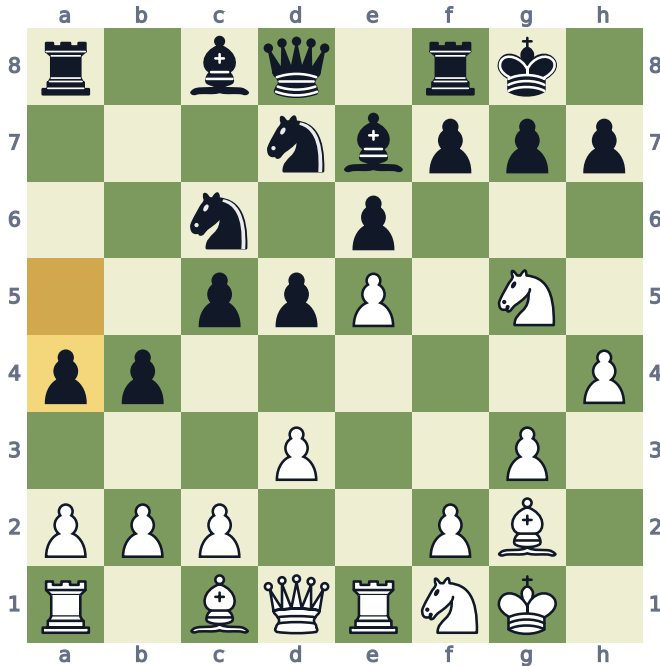
RULE | Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4



- h4: White creates a possible kingside hook and supports h5.
- a5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- b4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Ng5: White reroutes a knight to g5; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- a4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? White's attacking or positional plan is: White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece. The line fails as a template when: Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

STORE THIS | Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

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ANSWER KEY

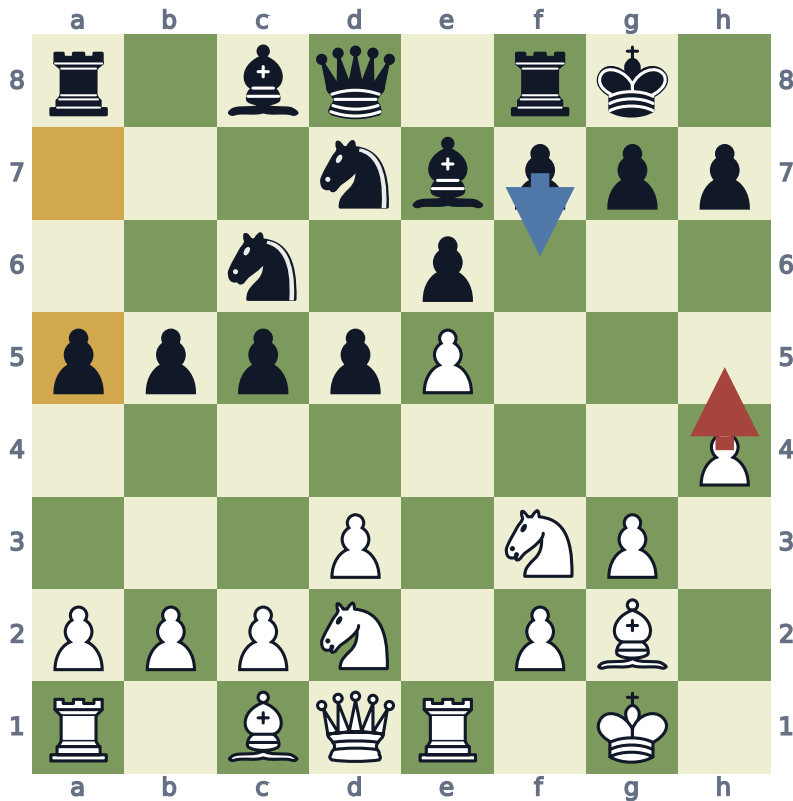
1. f4 reinforces e5 and prepares f5, but it weakens e3 and the king's diagonal while committing another pawn to the attack. 2. Black strikes with ...f6, uses the e3 square, or opens the queenside before White's pawn mass reaches the king. 3. White plays f4 only when e5 needs support or f5 will create an entry square for a piece. 4. Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space? 5. Building an impressive pawn chain that leaves the pieces no lines and the king fewer defenders.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 24 plies from memory, then replay: 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: f5 as a contact move



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces.

DECISION RULE

After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black chooses the capture that keeps lines closed, returns material if needed, and counterattacks d3 or the queenside.

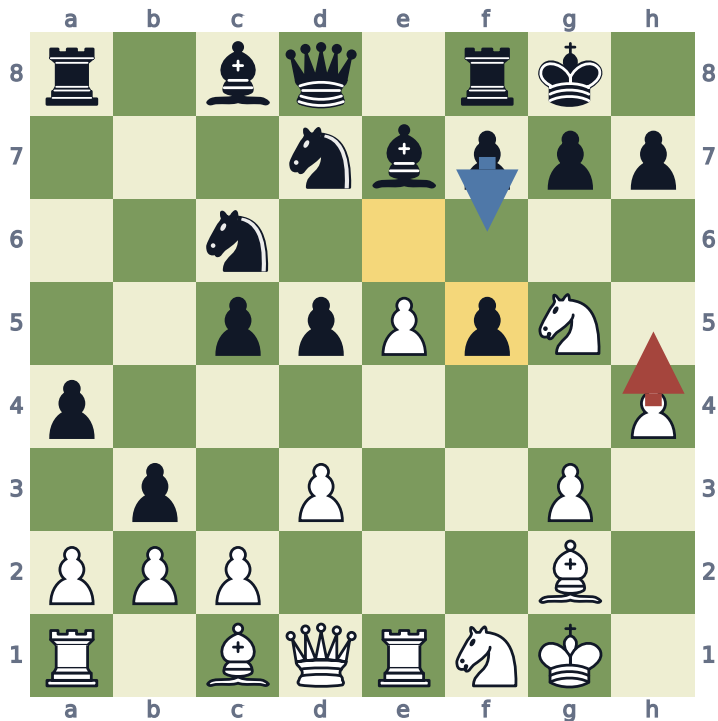
WHITE'S PLAN

White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn.

MEMORY RULE | f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn.

FAILURE MODE

Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

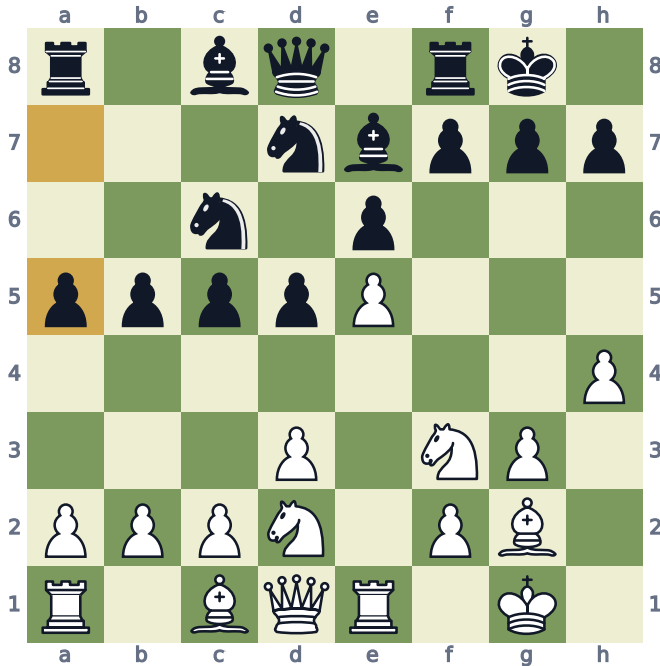
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Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- b5: Black gains queenside space and begins the race against White's king attack.
- e5: White gains kingside space and drives the f6 knight while fixing a pawn-chain target.
- Nd7: Black reroutes a knight to d7; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- h4: White creates a possible kingside hook and supports h5.
- a5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? White's attacking or positional plan is: White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn. The line fails as a template when: Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

STORE THIS | f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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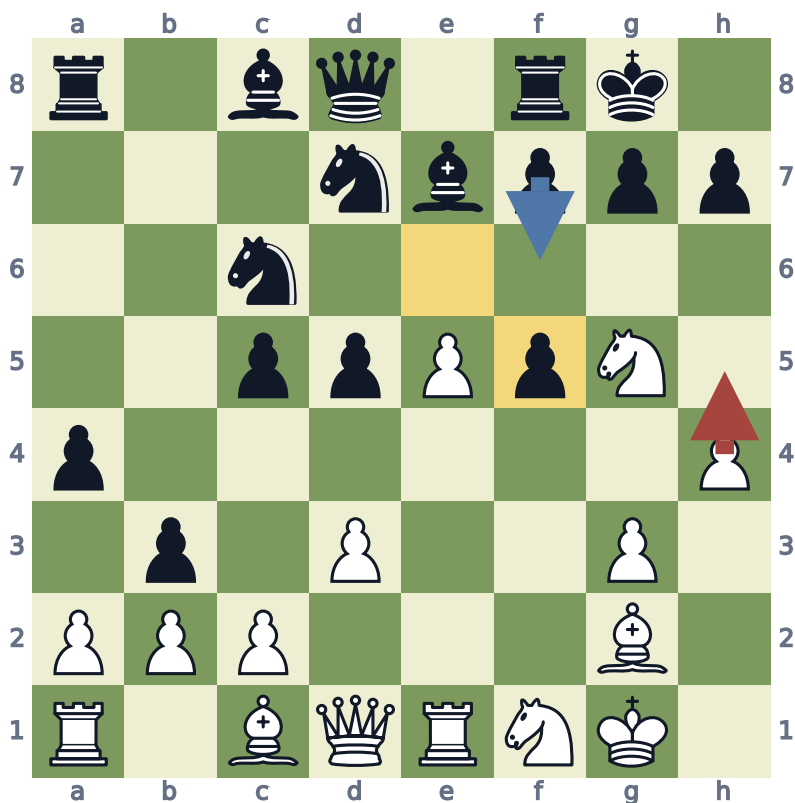
1. f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces. 2. Black chooses the capture that keeps lines closed, returns material if needed, and counterattacks d3 or the queenside. 3. White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn. 4. After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? 5. Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: f5 as a contact move



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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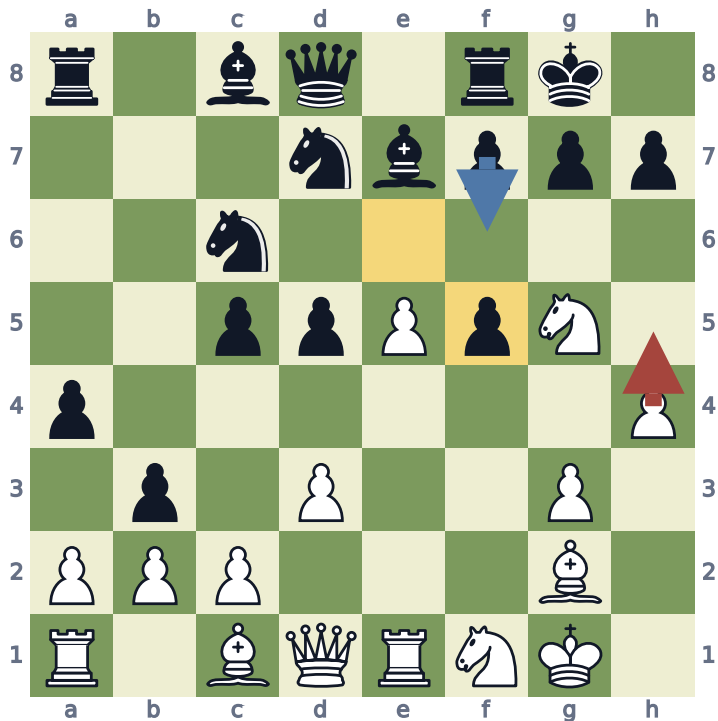
WHITE'S PLAN

White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn.

MEMORY RULE | f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

Black chooses the capture that keeps lines closed, returns material if needed, and counterattacks d3 or the queenside.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn.

FAILURE MODE

Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

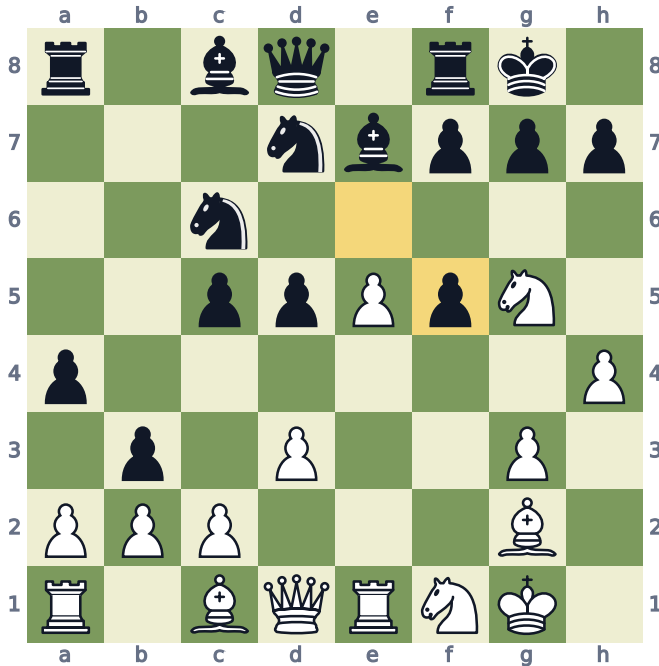
RULE | f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3 14. f5 exf5



- Ng5: White reroutes a knight to g5; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- a4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- f4: White supports e5 and prepares contact on f5 while loosening the king.
- b3: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- f5: White makes line-opening contact with e6 or g6.
- exf5: Black releases tension on f5; recalculate the pawn chain, open files, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? White's attacking or positional plan is: White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn. The line fails as a template when: Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

STORE THIS | f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. f5 makes contact with e6 and g6, can open the f-file or e-file, and may sacrifice a pawn to release White's pieces. 2. Black chooses the capture that keeps lines closed, returns material if needed, and counterattacks d3 or the queenside. 3. White calculates the recapture, rook activation, and queen entry before committing the f-pawn. 4. After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure? 5. Playing f5 because it is thematic while Black can capture and leave White with no active recapture.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 28 plies from memory, then replay: 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3 14. f5 exf5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 031 Decode: When e5 gains useful time

Prompt: Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king?

Recall: e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

LESSON 032 Play: When e5 gains useful time

Prompt: Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king?

Recall: e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

LESSON 033 Decode: f4 supports the space advantage

Prompt: Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space?

Recall: Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

LESSON 034 Play: f4 supports the space advantage

Prompt: Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space?

Recall: Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

LESSON 035 Decode: f5 as a contact move

Prompt: After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure?

Recall: f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

LESSON 036 Play: f5 as a contact move

Prompt: After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure?

Recall: f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

When e5 gains useful time

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7

Decision: Where will the f6 knight go, and does its retreat help Black attack e5 or defend the king?

Memory: e5 must win a useful tempo, not merely a visible square.

CARD 2

f4 supports the space advantage

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4

Decision: Does f4 defend a real target and prepare a concrete contact, or is it only adding visual space?

Memory: Every attacking pawn move must defend something or prepare contact.

CARD 3

f5 as a contact move

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. Re1 b5 9. e5 Nd7 10. h4 a5 11. Nf1 b4 12. Ng5 a4 13. f4 b3 14. f5 exf5

Decision: After ...exf5, which white piece recaptures or uses the opened line, and is the e5 pawn still secure?

Memory: f5 is a line-opening operation; identify the piece that enters the line.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
031 Decode: When e5 gains useful time	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
032 Play: When e5 gains useful time	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
033 Decode: f4 supports the space advantage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
034 Play: f4 supports the space advantage	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
035 Decode: f5 as a contact move	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
036 Play: f5 as a contact move	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.